AI-ENABLED MARKET MAPPING & SOURCING

Acquiring an executive search firm

A 12-month, AI-leveraged search for a boutique executive-search firm. A lean tool stack does the volume work; a human owns every relationship.

Strategy

THE APPROACH

The engine is a proprietary, AI-leveraged outbound flow that sources off-market firms at scale (the rest of this deck). On top of it we run three human channels that buy what the data can't: a full read of the market, a quality signal on each firm, and warm introductions.

1 · Brokers and intermediaries

Engage M&A brokers despite high success fees. They give a full lay of the land — the firms actively for sale — and a market benchmark to compare against our off-market, proprietary flow.

2 · An in-industry advisor

Retain a senior in-house recruiter who has hired many placement firms. They open referrals and tell us who placed executives well and who didn't — quality signal no database carries.

3 · Executive referrals

Ask placed executives who placed them. Cold firm names become warm, differentiated introductions to the search firms that actually delivered.

Note: These three channels complement the proprietary flow; brokers also provide the market benchmark we score our own sourcing against.

Goals and timeline

TIME TO CLOSE

12 months

Signed & closed acquisition vs. an 18–30 month traditional search.

REPLY RATE TARGET

20%

Blended multi-channel response. High by design on a small, high-value universe.

SOURCING CADENCE

75/mo

About 18 well-researched firms a week. Quality over volume.

OUTCOME

1 deal

One acquisition that fits the buy-box, financed and closed.

Workstream	M1	M2	M3	M4	M5	M6	M7	M8	M9	M10	M11	M12
1 · Sourcing + research Continuous · 75 firms/mo	runs continuously, even while LOIs are out											
2 · Outreach Contact, reply, qualifying calls		20% reply → 75 qualified calls										
3 · LOI / negotiations Deep dives, IOIs, 2–3 LOIs in parallel					5 LOIs							
4 · Due diligence QoE, legal, financing → close								lead deal				★
SOURCING / MO	40	80	80	80	80	80	80	80	80	70	▼	—

Continuous pipeline · Deal execution · Close-out · ★ Close (M12)

Note: Every number derives from one deal worked backward; sourcing runs continuously, even while LOIs are out, so the pipeline never goes cold if a deal falls through.

The sourcing funnel

FUNNEL STAGE	CONVERSION TO NEXT	COUNT NEEDED
Sourced & contacted firm	20%	750
Reply	50%	150
Qualified intro call	20%	75
Deep dive / mgmt meeting (IOI)	33%	15
LOI submitted	40%	5
LOI accepted (exclusivity)	50%	2
Closed deal		1

Source: Conversion benchmarks per Stanford GSB / HBS search-fund studies.

Total addressable market

FROM THE WHOLE INDUSTRY DOWN TO THE RIGHT-FIT POOL

2,500–3,500 US search firms

500–1,000 boutiques

Hundreds, NE

$1–10M EBITDA, owner-operated, Northeast-anch

THE RIGHT-FIT UNIVERSE

- 2,500–3,500 employer executive-search firms in the US.
- Filter to retained boutiques at $1–10M EBITDA: **500–1,000 nationally**, a few hundred in the Northeast.
- Because the universe is small, reaching the target LOIs and a close depends on a high conversion rate, not volume: the 20% reply target is what carries the funnel.

Sources: IBISWorld, Census / SICCODE, AESC.

Note: A small universe means reaching the target LOIs and a close depends on conversion, not volume.

Milestones

MONTH	MILESTONE
M3	Reply rate measured against the 20% target.
M6	375 firms contacted, roughly half the addressable universe engaged.
M7	First LOI submitted.
M12	★ Close. Acquisition complete.

Source: Pace expectations per Stanford GSB / HBS search-fund studies.

Stack principles

1. **One agent runs everything.** Every tool is chosen so its data and operations feed a single coding agent (Claude Code, Codex, or Cursor) that aggregates, processes, and acts on them. The priority is a tool exposing an MCP server or open API the agent can call directly.

2. **Differentiated data.** When we spend, we prioritize sources that give us a view other buyers don't already have. Commodity data is used at its free tier, or skipped.

3. **Fit to the search.** Sources are matched to this specific search (executive search, owner-operated firms, demand-driven screening) rather than generic market subscriptions.

Note: Four layers follow, market research, sourcing, CRM and capture, and outbound, each leading with the recommendation, then the comparison.

The stack at a glance

CATEGORY	RECOMMENDED PICK	APPROACH	/ MO
Market Research	BLS / Census / FRED + Revelio + IBISWorld (free)	Free data, fed to the agent	$0
Company Sourcing	Clay (core) + Apollo (own-key); Grata optional	Build-led, discovery free	$264–574
CRM + capture	Attio + Granola (Meet) + OpenPhone (phone)	Buy cheap, AI-native	$37–96
Outbound	Superhuman + Handwrytten	Two tools, send as a person	$132
All-in recurring			**$430–800**

Agent column (next slides): ● ships an MCP server · ◐ open API only · ○ closed or manual.

Market research

VENDOR	WHAT IT MEASURES	2026 PRICE	AGENT	VERDICT
BLS / Census / FRED	Hiring (JOLTS), occupation & industry growth, employment by industry × metro	Free APIs	●	RECOMMENDED
Revelio Labs	Headcount, hiring & attrition by role × industry × geography	Free RPLS	●	FREE TIER
IBISWorld	Underlying-industry growth + the Executive Search report	$0 via Searchfunder	○	ONE-TIME READ

RECOMMENDATION

Free government data. No paid feeds.

- **BLS, Census, FRED:** hiring and industry-growth signals through public APIs.
- **Revelio**'s free tier covers workforce data.
- **IBISWorld** is free because Searchfunder gives members unlimited access, including the Executive Search report.
- The agent scores demand under each firm at $0. Paid feeds ($6k to $85k a year) are built for institutions.

Sources: per-vendor links inline. Pricing is 2026; re-verify at point of use.

Company sourcing

VENDOR	WHAT IT IS	2026 PRICE	AGENT	VERDICT
Clay	Orchestration + AI enrichment + personalization; wraps providers. Owns no target database	$185 / $495	●	RECOMMENDED
Apollo.io	Verified personal emails via own-key into Clay; for deliverability, not discovery	$79/mo	●	RECOMMENDED
Grata	Discovery accelerator; estimates only, thin below 10 people, built for mid-market	$10k–100k/yr	◐	OPTIONAL
ZoomInfo	Enterprise contact database; priced for large sales teams	$15k–40k/yr	◐	NOT USED

RECOMMENDATION

Clay for the build ($185 to $495/mo). Apollo for emails ($79/mo).

- Search firms are public: websites, named partners, LinkedIn, directories.
- **Clay** scrapes and structures it, and Claygent enriches each firm.
- **Apollo** buys verified emails to protect deliverability, then cancels once the list is enriched.
- Per firm we get the site, partners, headcount, emails, and inferred succession flags.

Sources: per-vendor links inline. Pricing is 2026; sales-gated figures are estimates.

CRM and capture

VENDOR	WHAT IT IS	2026 PRICE	AGENT	VERDICT
Attio	AI-native CRM; MCP with write access, so the agent maintains the pipeline	$0–59/seat	●	RECOMMENDED
Granola	Google Meet via system audio, no bot; native Windows; MCP transcripts	$14/mo	●	RECOMMENDED
OpenPhone / Quo	Softphone with native call transcription; webhook pushes the transcript to the repo	$23/mo	◐	RECOMMENDED
Affinity	Best automatic email capture, but priced for funds	$2k/seat/yr	●	SKIP

RECOMMENDATION

Attio (free to $59/seat), with Granola and OpenPhone for capture. About $37/mo for capture.

- **Attio**'s MCP write access lets the agent maintain the pipeline, not the searcher.
- **Granola** records Meet on Windows with no bot; **OpenPhone** transcribes every call.
- Both feed one endpoint; the agent summarizes, pulls next steps, and updates the pipeline.
- Disclose recording at the top of every call, and treat it as all-party consent.

Sources: per-vendor links inline. Recording-consent law ranges one-party to all-party; disclose on every owner call.

Outbound

VENDOR	CHANNEL · WHAT IT IS	2026 PRICE	AGENT	VERDICT
Superhuman	Email · AI 1:1 client; read + link tracking, follow-up reminders; real inbox	$33/mo	○	RECOMMENDED
Handwrytten	Mail · real pen-and-ink cards via API; the channel founders open	$99/mo	◐	RECOMMENDED
Apollo sequences	Email · automated follow-up cadence from your own mailbox; already owned	$0 marginal	◐	OPTIONAL
Smartlead / Instantly	Email · volume cold-send infrastructure; the wrong fit at 190/mo	$94/mo	●	NOT USED

RECOMMENDATION

Two tools: Superhuman ($33/mo) for email, Handwrytten ($99/mo) for cards.

- **Superhuman** sends from your real domain with tracking, AI drafting, and follow-up reminders.
- **Handwrytten** sends a real pen-and-ink card, the channel a founder who ignores email will still open.
- LinkedIn is sent by hand, and phone runs on the OpenPhone line. Neither needs a new tool.
- Measure replies, not opens: Apple's privacy change makes open-rates meaningless.

Sources: per-vendor links inline. Pricing is 2026; re-verify at point of use.

Human vs. AI

AI cannot replace the relationship

Every personalized touch, the emails and notes that go out and every call, is written or edited and sent by a human.

AI accelerates the team

Research, enrichment, drafting, scoring, scheduling, transcription, and pipeline hygiene: the volume work that frees the searcher for owners.

AI is only as good as its controls

Output reflects the goals and examples we set, so it needs iteration and feedback before it earns more autonomy.

FUNNEL STAGE	HUMAN OWNS	AI ACCELERATES	MODE
Sourcing & research	Approves the universe and the judgment calls	Discovers, enriches, scores, compiles dossiers	AI-LED
Outreach: email, notes, cards	Writes or edits and approves every message	Drafts a first pass from the owner's dossier	HUMAN-LED
The conversation: calls, meetings	Every call and meeting, start to finish	Transcribes and summarizes after, pulls next steps	HUMAN-ONLY
Pipeline & follow-up	Sets priorities and the next move	Maintains the CRM, schedules, surfaces reminders	AI-LED

Principle: The high-stakes touches stay human at every stage. What changes over time is how much the searcher has to check around them.